capital. With the administration centred in Thimphu, the efficiency of the government could be improved.

Bhutan's leaders were also more astute in handling their relations with India than the controversial royal couple in Gangtok. Like Sikkim, Bhutan sought more direct, international links, but did so more discreetly and without antagonizing India. Without much ado, already in 1962, Bhutan joined the Plan for Cooperative, Economic, and Social Development in Asia and the Pacific, better known as the Colombo Plan. In 1966, the government in Thimphu notified India of its desire to become a member of the UN and, when that was granted in 1971, it was a major foreign policy breakthrough for Bhutan.

The third druk gyalpo, Jigme Dorji Wangchuk, who is seen as the father of modern Bhutan, died on 21 July 1972 while receiving medical treatment in Nairobi, Kenya. He was only 43, but had had a series of health problems and suffered several heart attacks before his death. The first druk gyalpo had adopted a unique symbol of his royal authority: a crown surmounted by the head of a raven, which represented the raven-headed Mahakala, Bhutan's guardian deity.[36] The Raven Crown was now passed on to Jigme Dorji Wangchuk's only son, Jigme Singye Wangchuk, who, on 24 July, became the fourth druk gyalpo. He was only a few months shy of 17 when he became the head of what was then still an absolute monarchy. But the young druk gyalpo was very well educated and more accustomed to the modernities of the outside world than any of his predecessors. After attending St. Joseph's College in Darjeeling, he continued his studies at the Heatherdown Preparatory School in England where, Prince Andrew, Prince Edward, and Britain's future Prime Minister David Cameron studied after him, and, later, at the Ugyen Wangchuk Academy in Paro.

The reign of the fourth druk gyalpo, which lasted until he abdicated in favour of his son Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuk in January 2006, saw rapid economic and social development based on the export of hydroelectric power to India, high-end tourism, and cottage industry. This has enabled Bhutan's government to provide its citizens with free education and health care. A new middle class has emerged and even though farmers remain poor, they are, by and large, self-sufficient and there is no outright misery in the countryside.

The fourth druk gyalpo also introduced a form of democracy and negotiated the 2007 agreement with India, which established Bhutan as a